



Bonaventure: Through the Crucified, or Not at All

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 15–18

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About This Book

You already know a Bonaventure if you know a holy card: brown habit, cardinal's hat, a seraph somewhere in the gold leaf. That image is not false. It is late, useful, and incomplete.

This booklet argues. It uses the *Itinerarium Mentis in Deum* (1259) in Ewert Cousins's English as the spine. It uses *On the Reduction of the Arts to Theology* (Zachary Hayes) as the claim about knowledge. It uses the *Collationes in Hexaëmeron* 1.11 as the Christ-center sentence. It uses the *Legenda Maior* (1263) as an official Francis, not as the only Francis. It will not settle 1217 versus 1221. It will not baptize the dishwashing cardinal. It will not pretend illumination is a solved homework problem.

Six sittings: Paris and the making of a Franciscan intellectual; La Verna and the six wings; vestige/image/likeness against pantheism and plunder; illumination versus Aquinas; poverty, Spirituals, and the official life; *reductio*, Mary-and-Martha, Lyon, unfinished Sabbath.

If you want a mascot who “just loved Jesus and books,” stop. If you want a map that refuses a side door, read.

Chapter 1: The Chair That Could Have Been Empty



Illustration for Chapter 1

You are trained to start saints at the miracle. Bonaventure's dossier will feed you one: a dying boy, Francis's prayer, "O bona ventura." Keep it in the late-story column. The name

stuck. The fever-scene is not how the *Itinerarium* begins. The *Itinerarium* begins by calling on the Father of lights.

Giovanni di Fidanza is from Bagnoregio, a ridge town in the papal lands. Birth year: 1217 or 1221. Hagiography prefers overlap with Francis. History prefers the “or.” He takes the Franciscan habit around 1243 and enters the Paris house of studies under Alexander of Hales. Aristotle is arriving. Some want the books locked. Some want them crowned. Bonaventure’s habit is to use a tool and name its limit. That is already a theology of knowledge.

1254: *licentia docendi*, Franciscan chair. Nearby, Thomas Aquinas. Colleagues. The cartoon “mystic versus rationalist” is a later convenience. They split on how certainty is explained, how Christ sits in the system, and whether theology’s first gesture is proof or prayer. They do not need hatred to split.

The anti-mendicant controversy is not color. Secular masters wanted friars out of chairs. If they had won, this booklet has no subject — no inaugural *De reductione*, no *Breviloquium* for brothers who cannot live inside Lombard, no seventeen years of a Minister General who still writes like a master. The chair is a political fact. It is also a spiritual risk: the Order of lesser brothers now speaks from the loudest school in the Latin West.

Works of the teaching years: *Commentary on the Sentences*; *De reductione artium ad theologiam*; *Breviloquium* (seven parts as seven days — theology as a week that ends in rest); disputed questions on Christ’s knowledge; *Lignum Vitae*, twelve fruits of Christ’s life. The Tree is not a dumbed-down *Itinerarium*. It is a different method: narrative, imaginative, crib-cousin to Greccio. Francis wanted the Incarnation seen. Bonaventure writes a tree you can enter. Same mind. If you split scholastic and devout into two men, you are the one inventing.

Clare is not in this hall. She is in a cloister fighting for a legal nothing. Francis is dead and already many. Bonaventure is the interpreter who will have to govern the many. Interpreters look like traitors to people who wanted the founder frozen. Sometimes they are. Sometimes they are the only reason a fire still has a grate.

Scholarly debate, already: is the childhood healing a historical core or a narrative job that pre-authorizes the later Minister General? You do not need to answer to read the texts. You need to notice that Bonaventure’s own pages do not lean on that scene. They lean on Francis as exemplar and on Christ as center. Privilege the pages.

The *Breviloquium* is the dogmatic twin of the later mystical map. Trinity, creation, fall, Incarnation, sacraments, last things, seventh-day rest. Harry’s 1.2 is right that the seven-day structure is an argument: creation’s week is the shape of the science. A high-school culture

that treats theology as extra-credit opinion will miss the claim. He thinks this is how the world is.

Do not skip the Sentences commentary because it is huge and this booklet is not. The point is formation: he is not a hermit who later learned Latin. He is a Latin master who later goes to a mountain. Order matters. Halo last.

The Sentences years also trained a habit he never dropped: every ascent is an argument with authorities. Augustine, Dionysius, Hugh of St. Victor, Aristotle as limited tool, Lombard as classroom. When he later writes a mystical map, he is not forgetting that classroom. He is ordering it to union. A reader who wants “just the spirituality” is asking him to betray his own formation. A reader who wants “just the system” is asking him to betray La Verna.

Alexander of Hales’s death in 1245 is not trivia. The early Franciscan school at Paris is a chain. Bonaventure inherits a chair that already believed theology could be both Franciscan and scholastic. He did not invent that gamble. He became its most famous proof and, as Minister General, its most stressed proof.

Big Idea

Bonaventure’s vocation is habit plus chair. Drop the habit and he is a Paris career. Drop the chair and he is a holy card. The anti-mendicant fight shows the chair was never neutral. The Tree and the *Breviloquium* show the same mind refusing to split devotion from doctrine.

Practice

1. Two-column source log: document / late story. Birth year, healing, name, Paris chair, Aquinas “friendship,” *Tree of Life*. One page. No halo verbs. 2. Read *Breviloquium*’s seven-part outline (any reliable contents page). Write 200 words on why a “short book” still ends in Sabbath rather than in a glossary. 3. Map the anti-mendicant controversy in five sentences. Then write one sentence on what your school would lose if a whole class of teachers were expelled for being the wrong kind of religious. 4. Compare ten minutes of a STEM problem set with ten minutes of slow reading of a Psalm. Do not rank them. Describe the different lights. Deliverable: a four-line journal.

Research Prompt

This is the one outside-reading task. Using Cousins’s prologue to the *Itinerarium* and any one chapter of Cullen, *Bonaventure* (Oxford, 2006), argue in 750–1000 words whether Bonaventure should be introduced first as a Paris master or first as Francis’s interpreter. Cite pages. Do not use the childhood healing as a premise. The order of beginnings is the method of this booklet.

Chapter 2: Six Illuminations and the Side Door



Illustration for Chapter 2

1257: Minister General, about forty, not a volunteer. John of Parma cannot hold Spirituals and Relaxati. Alexander IV wants a change. The job is a storm.

1259: La Verna, thirty-third year after Francis's death. Bonaventure says he sought peace of spirit after Francis's example, seventh in the generalate, a sinner succeeding a saint. While thinking of mental ascents, the seraph of 1224 returns as structure. Six wings, six illuminations from creatures to God. He writes a travel plan.

Cousins: "The figure of the six wings of the Seraph stands for the six stages of illumination, which begin with creatures and lead up to God, to whom no one has proper access except through the Crucified." The Gospel's thief-and-gate line is not decoration. It is a veto on spiritual technique that skips the Passion.

Stages, without the holy-card blur: (1) vestiges in the sensible world; (2–3) the soul's faculties as image — memory, intellect, will; (4) the image cracked, restored only in Christ; (5) God as one, Being; (6) God as Trinity, self-diffusive good; (7) apex of affection carried into superluminous darkness. Chapter 4 is the hinge. The first three rungs can be misread as natural theology. Four shatters the misreading. Franciscan difference from a purely philosophical ascent: no climb that is not through the Incarnate Image.

Before the map, a warning that should wreck a certain kind of AP student: do not believe reading sufficient without unction, speculation without devotion, investigation without wonder, knowledge without love, study without grace. The exterior mirror is nearly useless if the mind's mirror is filthy. First the bite of conscience. Then the rays. Otherwise the light digs a worse pit.

This is not anti-intellectual. It is an account of what intellect is for. The *Itinerarium* uses scholastic categories as rungs of a spiritual exercise. You are not done when you can define vestige. You are invited to ascend. A university that only defines has already taken the side door.

1273 will recast the journey as six days in the *Collations on the Hexaëmeron*. Day one: light. Day seven would be Sabbath. He leaves for Lyon. Unfinished. The *Itinerarium* already knew the stop: ask grace not instruction, desire not understanding, groaning not diligence, darkness not clarity, not light but fire. Two sisters: psychological map, cosmic week. Both refuse a closed system.

Scholarly debate: is the seraph-structure a genuine flash at La Verna or a literary architecture fitted after the fact onto Francis's vision? The prologue presents it as insight in a place. Literary art and historical pilgrimage are not mutually exclusive. What you may not do is treat the six wings as a personality quiz.

Governance is inside the mysticism. A Minister General meditating the founder's body-vision while the Order fights over the founder's poverty is not on vacation. The map is an argument about what Francis was for: not a faction, a way through the Crucified.

Big Idea

The *Itinerarium* is a travel plan whose door is the Crucified. Six wings begin with creatures. Chapter 4 forbids a self-powered climb. Knowledge without love is named as a pit before the first rung. Unfinished later collations prove the same humility: theology knows when to stop.

Practice

1. Outline the seven chapters of the *Itinerarium* on one page. Mark chapter 4 in a different ink. Write 150 words on what collapses if you delete it. 2. Copy the “reading without unction” list by hand. Annotate the pair you split most often. Keep the sheet in whatever binder you actually use. 3. Walk six outdoor minutes without audio. At the end, write what you treated as a vestige and what you treated as noise. No posting. 4. Read *Itinerarium* 7.6 (Cousins). Paraphrase “ask grace, not instruction” in six words. Then list one instruction you still owe this week. The point is both.

Reflect

Where in your schooling are you being trained to take a side door — competence without conscience, analysis without wonder — and what would it cost to refuse it without performing piety?

Chapter 3: The World Is a Book, Not God



Illustration for Chapter 3

Exemplarism: created things copy eternal ideas in God's mind. The world is signs. A tree is a vestige, a footprint. Footprints are not the passer-by.

Ranks, which are the journey: vestige (matter shows that God passed), image (the soul's three powers more specifically reflect Trinity), likeness (Christ the perfect image; grace toward participation). Flatten the ranks and you get pantheism or dualism. Bonaventure blesses neither. Franciscan love of creatures is grammatical. You love the sentence. You do not marry the ink.

Itinerarium 1.2 (Cousins): place the first step at the bottom; put the sensible world before you as a mirror through which you pass over to God, the highest creative Artist. Jacob's ladder from below. Senses are rung one, not a mistake. A holiness that begins by insulting dirt is not this holiness.

Lynn White Jr. (1967) blamed Western Christianity for nature-as-warehouse. Francis is often produced as the exception. Bonaventure is the exception's grammar. Ilia Delio and *Laudato Si'* can enter a conversation as later reception, not as if they were hidden in 1259. He did not write a climate paper. He wrote that matter is legible and first. That already fights two modern sermons: plunder, and nature-cult.

De reductione belongs in this chapter as well as in the last. Mechanical arts, sense, philosophy, Scripture: four lights from the Father of lights (James 1:17). A cobbler's light is real. It is not the sun. *Reducere* is lead-back, not shrink. A workshop that will not go home becomes an idol. A piety that burns the workshop lies about the Father.

If you have the Francis booklet, this is Layer-3 prose under Layer-1 song. Brother Sun survives. The ranks are why the Canticle is not a nature religion. The cluster is one argument in three voices: Francis sings, Clare empties, Bonaventure reads.

Scholarly debate: is exemplarism a metaphysical thesis (real divine ideas) or a contemplative method (treat the world as readable)? Cullen will not let you skip the metaphysics. A high-school reading can still use the method without pretending to have settled the ontology. What you may not do is call the world God because that would be "more spiritual."

Digital cousin (Harry 5.3): the first rung assumes attention. A feed designed to shatter looking is not a new seraph. It is a machine for stalling at noise. The answer is not a Luddite pose. It is whether you can still put the sensible world in front of you as a mirror for more than seven seconds.

Big Idea

Creation is sacramental: a participating sign, not identity with God. The first rung is looking. Stopping at the look is stall. Plunder and pantheism are both illiteracy.

Practice

1. Three-shelf diagram: vestige / image / likeness. One object, one interior act, the cross. Under it, one anti-pantheism sentence you could defend to a friend who loves “the universe.” 2. 24-hour footprint log: five created things that pointed beyond themselves. Mark any that you treated as loot. 3. Read Francis’s Canticum (complete, including Sister Death if you have it) beside *Itinerarium* 1. Mark where song and ranks need each other. 4. One lab period: write four sentences on how measurement is a way of looking, and where looking still owes thanks.

Reflect

When you say you “love nature,” which rank are you actually using — vestige, image, likeness — and which forbidden collapse (God / trash) is your usual error?

Chapter 4: Certainty and Borrowed Oil



Illustration for Chapter 4

Augustine: unchanging truths are seen in God's light as color in the sun. Bonaventure inherits illumination into a century that has just met Aristotle. Abstraction from sense is not denied. It is judged insufficient to explain necessity. Finite, fallen faculties know particulars. The must-be-so of $2+2=4$, or of murder's wrong, needs eternal Truth shining.

Aquinas (*De Veritate* 11, and the broader Aristotelian line): faculties work because they are well made. The knower can check abstraction against sense. If the decisive light is not under the knower's control, how does the knower know that he knows? Bonaventure's counter: well-made tools do not yet explain universality and necessity. Dependence is not irrationality. It is the condition of reason.

Harry 7.1's three modern readings — hold them:

Concurrence. Illumination is the condition of the mind's natural acts, not a rival act. Charitable to homework.

Occasionalism. God alone knows; faculties are occasions. Fatal to agency. Fear this reading if you care about algebra.

Regulative. A theological reminder without a mechanism. Maybe too weak for the texts.

Do not declare a winner. Learn why each exists. Illumination is the epistemology of exemplarism: the world is knowable because it reflects God, and the mind knows because God lights it. Two sides of one coin.

Method-split with Aquinas is as important as the doctrine-split. *Summa* opens with questions, including proofs. *Itinerarium* opens with groaning through Christ crucified. Same faith. Different first gesture. First gestures train what you think theology is for: science of revealed truth, or spiritual exercise that uses science inside prayer. High-school culture will try to make you pick a team mascot. Refuse.

Pastoral edge, still intellectual: knowledge without love is a pit already named in the prologue. Illumination that produces a proud knower has failed its own light. The digital cousin returns: a mind that cannot attend cannot take rung one, let alone argue about necessity.

Open question you will meet again in adult: can this epistemology be translated if theism is dropped? If not, say so. Do not smuggle God in as a metaphor for “awe.”

Big Idea

Illumination claims that certain knowledge is borrowed light. It is an account of possibility, not a substitute for thinking. The live fight with Aquinas is autonomy versus dependence. Occasionalism is the failure mode. Knowledge without love is the moral failure mode.

Practice

1. One page: Aquinas's well-made faculties vs Bonaventure's borrowed light, using one math truth and one moral truth. No memes. 2. Name which of the three modern readings you fear most and why, in 200 words. Cite Harry 7.1 or Cullen. 3. For three days, when you

understand something hard, note whether your first interior move is thanks or display. Private log. 4. Read James 1:17. Chart four lights in your week: craft, sense, argument, Scripture. Which one you treat as a sun.

Reflect

If your mind is a lamp, whose oil is it — and what changes in your studying if you answer honestly?

Chapter 5: Official Francis, Legal Poverty, Burning Factions



Illustration for Chapter 5

The Order in 1257 is a civil war with liturgies. Spirituals: Testament without gloss, absolute poverty, suspicion of schools. Relaxati: mission at scale, houses, books, usable goods. John of

Parma cannot govern it. Joachimite heat (an Age of the Spirit that outruns Church) scares popes. Secular masters want mendicants gone. Bonaventure's three moves: moderation, institutions, a story.

Poverty: individual nothing; use without ownership under papal legal fiction. Spirituals hear betrayal of the *Testament*. Moderates hear oxygen. Clare's decades-long fight is poverty as *end* — empty space God fills. Bonaventure's is poverty as *means* — empty hands for preaching, service, contemplation. All three are Franciscan. None is the only. A reader who "sides" in a paragraph is not reading. A reader who pretends they agreed is lying.

Institutions: formation, provinces, visitation, education. Rigorists smell pride. He thinks an ignorant preacher wounds the poor he meant to save. The university Franciscan is policy, not accident.

Story: *Legenda Maior*, Pisa 1263, official life. Celano 1228 and the Assisi Compilation 1240s are earlier, rawer, more jagged about money. Bonaventure's Francis is *alter Christus*; stigmata as seal; poverty as condition of mission. Tradition of destroying earlier lives: argued. Effect: for centuries the Church's Francis is this Francis. Modern recovery of earlier layers is not a conspiracy theory. It is philology. Dalarun and Burr will make you uncomfortable. Let them. Official stories do jobs: unify, calm, authorize. Hidden jobs are the problem.

After 1274 unity cracks. Spirituals later condemned. Seventeen years of walking friaries are not nothing. A map of peace is not peace. Lambert and Moorman hear wise institutionalization. Burr hears domestication of a radical charism. The deeper question is not a Twitter poll. It is whether a movement can survive its second generation without losing its soul or burning its children.

Scholarly debate (Harry 7.3): how much of "Francis" is Bonaventure's construction? Interpretation ≠ fabrication. Selection is still power. Privilege Layer 1 (Francis's own corpus) as veto, as the Francis booklet taught. Then read Celano. Then read Bonaventure. Order of beginnings again.

Do not use stigmata as a lab. Do not use Damietta here (that is Francis's booklet). Use the *Legenda* as what it is: a Minister General's theology of a founder.

Big Idea

Bonaventure loved Francis enough to interpret him for a house on fire. Poverty-as-means is a real position, not a shrug. The official life is a political-theological act. Read it beside earlier sources or you will meet only the grate, not the fire.

Practice

1. Tone chart: Assisi Compilation mood vs *Legenda Maior* mood. No invented quotations. 200 words. 2. 300 words: Clare's poverty-as-end vs Bonaventure's poverty-as-means. Pick a side only in the last five sentences, then defend the pick against the best objection. 3. Take "use without owning" and map it onto a library book. Then write where the analogy breaks (a book is not a friary). 4. Read Francis's *Testament* on not adding gloss (Armstrong/Brady if you have it). Write six sentences on why a Minister General would be tempted to gloss anyway.

Reflect

Who should own a founder's story — the first friends, or the people who have to keep thousands alive — and what do you owe the sources you did not privilege?

Chapter 6: Lead the Arts Home, Then Die at a Council



Illustration for Chapter 6

De reductio is short and arrogant in the holy sense: all knowledge ordered to theology, theology to contemplation. Hayes: the title is the life-project. None of the arts, including

philosophy, may stand self-sufficient. Four lights: mechanical, sense, philosophy, Scripture. Six differentiations if you split philosophy. Evening comes to every light; a seventh day of glory has no evening. That sentence should chasten a STEM-pride culture and a piety-pride culture at once.

Mary and Martha are a rhythm, not a scoreboard. Contemplation is prior. Return is completion. Sterile ascent, exhausted action: both fail. Bonaventure's biography is the argument: master, minister, cardinal, still a friar. Dishwashing-hat story: maybe. Fit: yes. 1273: Cardinal-Bishop of Albano. 1274: Second Council of Lyon, brief East–West formula (6 July), death 15 July. Reunion does not hold in the East. Canonized 1482. Doctor, 1588: Seraphic — heat, not costume wings.

Collations 1273: cosmic week, unfinished because Lyon. Harry's poignancy is allowed if you do not turn it into a novel. Theology that stops at the threshold of Sabbath is still theology. A system that explains even the silence is a different religion.

Hexaëmeron 1.11: intent to show that in Christ are hidden all treasures of wisdom and knowledge, and that he is the central point of all understanding. Christocentrism here is constitutive, not merely remedial (Hayes, *Hidden Center*). Aquinas's Christ as remedy for the fall is not an enemy sentence. It is a different center of gravity. Complementary is allowed. Collapse is not.

Open questions (Harry 7.4) you carry out of this booklet, unanswered: Can Christ-as-center survive pluralism without cheap exclusivism or cheaper universalism? Can illumination live if theism is dropped? Can the first rung survive engineered distraction? Can even moderate poverty be heard where "less" means failure? Can a plural university recover *reductio* without a shared altar? If you answer on a worksheet, you have not heard the questions.

Chapter 7 of the *Itinerarium* remains the last method: grace not instruction, desire not understanding, groaning not diligence, Spouse not teacher, darkness not clarity, fire not light. Then dishes, if you have dishes. Then a council, if you are called. Then an unfinished Sabbath, because you are not the seventh day.

Big Idea

All real skills are lights meant to go home. The Franciscan rhythm is ascent and return. Christ is the center of understanding, not a mascot for a faction. The last word is fire. The last scholarly honesty is an unfinished week.

Practice

1. Four-box reduction of one thing you actually do (sport, code, instrument, job). If you cannot lead it home without lying, write the lie you were tempted to tell. 2. Copy *Itinerarium*

7.6 by hand the night before a graded performance. Do the performance anyway. Note whether the fire-sentence made you softer or faker. Prefer neither: prefer true. 3. Timeline 1257–1274: generalate, *Itinerarium*, *Legenda*, cardinalate, Lyon, death. Two sentences on why mysticism that never touches a council is not this mysticism. 4. Write 250 words on the Seraphic title: what heat would look like in a life that still takes exams.

Reflect

Which of your lights have you been treating as self-made — and what would “leading it back” require this month that is not a caption?

For the Grown-Up Reader

Spine: Cousins, *Bonaventure* (Paulist, 1978); Hayes, *On the Reduction of the Arts to Theology* and *The Hidden Center*; de Vinck for Hexaëmeron; Cullen (Oxford, 2006). Francis layers: Celano, Assisi Compilation, *Legenda Maior*; Dalarun; Burr. Poverty: Lambert, Moorman; Clare contrast from Harry 2.6/7.2. Illumination debate: Harry 7.1; Aquinas *De Veritate* 11. Reception: White 1967; Delio; *Laudato Si'* as later, not back-read.

This band argues. It does not give spiritual direction, medical claims, or a verdict that Lyon “should” have lasted. One Research Prompt sits in chapter 1 on purpose: order of beginnings. Quotes are Bonaventure’s; late stories are labeled.

About WisdomForge

WisdomForge produces four age-adapted booklets for each figure: elementary (ages 5–10), middle (ages 11–14), high (ages 15–18), and adult. Each booklet covers the same person, ideas, and stories, but at a different level of depth and complexity. The elementary booklet tells stories. The middle booklet explains ideas. The high booklet argues and analyzes. The adult booklet engages with scholarly debates and primary sources. Read the one that fits — or read them all and watch the same figure grow.